against the concerned police officers.

'This was a surprising decision, as the production was not for a judgement but only for remand or bail. This was a clear judgement of "NOT GUILTY", without looking at the evidence,' pointed out Kiran later.

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The very same day, 15 January 1988, the lawyers of the Tees Hazari courts struck work. Hari Chand, the president of the Delhi Bar Association, declared that Rajesh Agnihotri had been falsely implicated by the students of St Stephen's College. This was because Rajesh Agnihotri had been involved in a scuffle with the students in a university special bus over the occupying of seats reserved for ladies. These students, Hari Chand claimed, beat him up and took him to the college hostel where he was illegally confined for a number of hours. On a subsequent date, when he had gone to the college to visit his father, who was a reader there in the Department of Botany, he was apprehended by the students and implicated in a false case. The then president of the St Stephen's Students' Union Society, Rajit Punhani, said: 'The incident [the lawyers' response to their colleague's arrest] erodes the confidence of the students in doing what the law requires them to do.' The metropolitan magistrate held that there was no prima facie case against the accused and therefore the case should be immediately dropped by the police. He recorded his views as follows: 'There's hardly any material placed on record which should justify further detention of the accused or his trial. Nobody has actually seen the accused taking out money and also no recovery was effected. Hence, prosecution and trial will serve no purpose …' (signed Pradeep Chaddha, 16 January 1988). What interest the police had in pursuing the case was, however, not a matter he would care to look into. Over the days the strike gathered momentum and, on 21 January, the lawyers formed a protest procession and marched, shouting slogans, to the office of the DCP (North), namely, Kiran Bedi. The protest marchers straightaway forced entry into her office and tried to get at Kiran. She was at that time in a meeting with all her district gazetted officers, reviewing the preparation for the forthcoming 26 January parade. All of them, sensing the intrusion, sprang to their feet, and immediately came between the lawyers and their DCP and succeeded in physically pushing them out. While doing so, they bolted Kiran in, protecting her from being attacked. The additional DCP, M. S. Sandhu, being the seniormost on the spot, took charge. Other officers with Sandhu included Prabhat Singh, assistant commissioner of police (ACP), D. L. Kashyap, Vinay Chaudhury, Ram Kumar and S. B. S. Tyagi.

The lawyers, for hours, remained menacing and kept on shouting filthy slogans. Sandhu continued to tolerate them, avoiding a confrontation with them as far as possible. But while he could tolerate the lawyers, some of his juniors could not. When a section of lawyers started to pull out the name plates and berets of some constables, the latter hit back, and all hell was let loose. Some lawyers were injured, as also some policemen. Photographers' cameras were smashed. It was all very wild. But the lawyers' biggest grouse was that they could not do to Kiran what they had come for. Now they wanted nothing short of her 'head'. They went on an indefinite strike and demanded her suspension. They alleged that Kiran had ordered a lathicharge on them and made sure that they were injured. They also wanted compensation for the injuries they had received, while simultaneously demanding 'nothing short of Kiran Bedi's suspension'. The incident had eyewitnesses at different stages of the rapidly changing scene. Therefore, the next day's newspapers published the versions of all sides: the injuries, the smashing of cameras, the filthy slogans and what have you!

It was clearly evident from published accounts in the newspapers that the lawyers wanted to humiliate the gender in the service and perhaps send out a larger message. Otherwise, how does one